

AN ISLE OF SUMMER

SANTA CATALINA

ITS HISTORY, CLIMATE, SPORTS AND ANTIQUITIES

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LOS ANGELES

R. Y. MCBRIDE, PUBLISHER

1901

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CHAPTER XIII.

THE WIND-SWEPT ISLAND OF SAN NICOLAS, AND SAN CLEMENTE.

ABOUT fifty miles off the coast of Santa Catalina, lies the island of San Nicolas—a veritable desert, wind-swept to such a degree that one might well imagine that the furies are guarding the island. San Nicolas, which is seven miles long and four or five wide, has no harbors, the anchorage being merely a lee under the low hills; the fact that the wind blows directly offshore making it possible for vessels to anchor here at certain seasons.

On this island, which has been the central point of a romance and tragedy of much interest, deserted and alone, Maria Better Than Nothing, the wild woman of San Nicolas, lived twenty years—long enough to forget her people and even her language. The story is as follows:

For centuries the island was inhabited by a race of hardy mariners who have left their monuments in large shell heaps and mounds that cover many acres. Less than one hundred years ago, the Franciscan fathers determined to take the natives away from the inhospitable island and provide them with homes around the various missions, where they could also be comfortably

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converted. With this object in view, a vessel was sent to the island, and after much difficulty the Indians, now reduced to about one hundred, were collected and taken aboard, deserting thousands of implements which their ancestors had used for centuries. When the vessel was about to sail, one of the women discovered that her child had been left behind. But it was blowing a gale and the vessel could not hold, so the captain sailed away, whereupon the frantic mother dashed into the sea and swam back to the shore making her way successfully through the surf. The captain of the vessel promised to return for the woman, but soon after his vessel was wrecked, and no attempt was made to rescue the poor Indian woman until twenty years after, when a priest determined to make an effort to learn whether she was alive. He enlisted the services of an otter hunter and several Indians, who in a small schooner, known as "Better Than Nothing," set sail for San Nicolas.

They landed on the island and very soon found evidence that some one was living there, but avoiding them. To make the search perfect, the men formed a line across the island at certain distances apart, which resulted in the discovery of the wild woman. She was sitting by a brush hut in a cañon, about which was a windbreak of whalebones and various material. She smiled and spoke to the Indians in a language they did not understand, but they fell on their faces before her as though to worship her. She offered them food and

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readily consented to go with them, and was taken aboard the schooner with a tame otter. She was dressed in the skins of birds, over which was a garment of sealskin. She was named "Maria Better Than Nothing," after the vessel, and by signs succeeded in telling some Indians on the mainland something of her history. At first she had mourned the loss of her friends; then the dogs killed her baby, and she wished to die and was sick for a long time.

She was taken to Santa Barbara, where Indians from all about were brought to her to see if they could understand her language; but without avail. She lived with different families at Santa Barbara, but civilization proved disastrous to her, and in less than three months she died. Her remarkable dress of feathers was sent to the Pope as a curiosity and the remains of the unfortunate woman found a resting place in the sanctified ground of the mission.

San Nicholas has proved a veritable treasure house for the archæologist, and tons of stone implements have been taken from various mounds on the island. One of the most remarkable shell mounds in the world is found here, being it is said nearly a mile long and ten feet in average height. On its wind-swept surface innumerable objects have been found, exposed during previous hurricanes, with the bodies of Indians facing each other, having been buried in a sitting position with hands clasped over the head. With many remains were buried such personal effects as mortars,

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ollas, flutes, jewel boxes of abalone, charms, flint spear-heads and almost every article needed by a hunting and fishing people, all formed from shell, bone or wood. Fishing lines were made of kelp; sinkers of stone with a groove worn around or a hole in the center; the hook was of elegant design and bore the barb upon the outside. One of the finest collections of these antiquities is owned by Mr. E. L. Doran, of Avalon, who has collected some unique specimens.

One of the greatest curiosities of San Nicolas, after all, is the summer wind. It tosses the sand dunes into the air like wraiths and keeps them continually moving and shifting. It has buried a stone house and so threatened another that the lone herder on the island often deserts it for shelter among the rocks near the sea-lion rookeries, fearing that it will be blown into the sea. For two successive years the writer as guest of Commodore Burnham, of the Santa Catalina Yacht Club, made the attempt to reach this inhospitable island. The first time the yacht was blown away; the second time the party was able to land, but owing to the terrific wind was glad to leave. Approaching, the island presented a flat and barren appearance, and the yacht finally came to under the lee of strange cliffs that rise from the sea, while to the north a long spit of sand extends to the east. In some places the cliff is worn by the combined forces of water and wind into marvelous shapes and is everywhere difficult of ascent. Some

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sailors have a superstition that the strange wind that blows from the island is from the souls of the natives, who resent this intrusion and the robbing of their graves.

The yacht's party soon had an experience with the wind. A black fog cloud came sweeping down over the island and the wind blew a hurricane, dissipating the fog and blowing until two o'clock in the morning. The landing was made in a heavy sea—a dangerous operation. The single inhabitant, a French herder, was standing on the sands, looking a typical Robinson Crusoe. He had a big hat strapped on under his chin, an old-fashioned shot gun over his shoulder, a cane in his other hand. Two half-breed shepherd dogs crouched near him. He evinced no desire to hear from the outer world; his one wish was for beans, which, unfortunately, could not be gratified. He had a small fortune at hand in the antiquities which he could pick up, but he was undoubtedly loath to despoil the graves, though not averse to pointing out the skeletons which had been uncovered here and there. Everywhere the wonderful evidences of the wind were apparent. In one cañon the writer photographed a section that almost seemed to have been carved by Titanic hands. There were great faces, impossible forms of animals, delicate lace-like tracery, all creating a wierd effect.

Reaching the summit after a hard climb over cliffs of yellow, blue, white, green and other shades, a mesa

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was found, almost level, extending for two or three miles. Not an object broke the level that appeared to be covered with small polished pebbles, arranged in windrows, that in the gale were blown about and raised into the air with the sand cyclone that accompanied them. For several miles the barren mesa, from which strange cañons reached down to the sea in every direction, was followed. One object of the visit was to locate the spot where Maria Better Than Nothing lived; but it was evident that the isle of winds was ever changing; named after St. Nicholas, it should be mild and gentle, but the reality is a veritable fury. The island seemed to be in the grasp of innumerable sand glaciers, which instead of moving down moved up and were ever shifting in the wind. The cañon in which the so-called wild woman is supposed to have lived is visible. A more deserted spot it is difficult to imagine—a river of sand winding up from the distant sea and covering everything. Here and there rise strange tree-like shapes that resemble the trunk of spectral trees, and which but add to the weirdness of the scene.

Everywhere were evidences of former occupation. Some of the party dug into the mounds, where curious stone slabs perhaps marked the graves of the ancestors of the wild woman. Pearl fishhooks, bone pipes and a flint spearhead were found, standing possibly just where they had been left; and tons of implements have been taken from the surface of the sand dunes.

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In one cañon a remarkable drapery of sandstone is being worn out by the wind. In others caves were found, one with strange hieroglyphics painted on the stone. Everything here tells of desolation and death; the sands strewn with the bones of a lost race, the deep cañons filling up with the deadly sand that conceals the remains of unnumbered people who lived here in the past.

The wind does not always blow at San Nicolas. The summer is the season of winds; in winter days and weeks follow when the island is at peace and the sand dunes seem sleeping. But fierce winter storms come suddenly and the island is not in good favor among the navigators of the Pacific.

To the north of Santa Catalina twenty-five miles or so lies Santa Barbara rock, about thirty acres in extent. It has no springs or water, consequently was never inhabited. To the south-west twenty miles lies San Clemente island, quite as interesting as Santa Catalina for its antiquities, but barren and more given over to wind and sand. The island is about twenty miles long and slopes from the north to the south, where the hills rise to the dignity of mountains. The island has an isthmus at the northern end where there is a large sand mesa covered here and there with evidences of ancient occupation. The island abounds in cañons, and on the west shore the inroads of the sand present a fascinating spectacle. There are veritable sand glaciers. They are moving up instead of down and have filled

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many deep cañons. The most remarkable feature being that the sand is not to-day a beach as it may have been and undoubtedly was a million years ago more or less, but is separated from the sea by a rocky and non sand-producing shore. In some of these cañons remarkable pits very deep and precipitous have been dug out by the wind and this sand stretch is one of the interesting features of the island. In it the skeletons of hundreds of aborigines have been found and when first visited by the author in 1886, it was strewn with human bones, abalone shells, broken pestles and mortars, and the thousand and one objects used by the lost race which formerly lived here. In many places the sand is covered with a pure white sheet of bleached snail shells. The caves have afforded mummied dogs wrapped in baskets made of sea weeds and cloth of the latter has been found in them, and many interesting objects there have been scattered to the four winds, but it is a matter of congratulation that Mr. E. L. Doran, of Avalon, has made a fine collection of the relics of these people, so the people of Avalon or Southern California will not have to go to London or New York in the future to study the history of the real California pioneers. San Nicolas Island is private property, a sheep herding station. San Clemente is government land leased to sheep owners. A long, heavy swell usually runs in the San Clemente Channel in the afternoon, which can be avoided by making the run early in the morning. Aside from its archæological interest,

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the island is a splendid fishing ground abounding in yellowtail, sea bass and all the game fishes that mark Santa Catalina as the sea anglers' paradise. Its faults lie in the lack of good harbors and the strong winds which have left their mark on the sand dunes of centuries.